Turning the Other Cheek: The Theology of Survival and Defense

A Sermon for Shabbat and Sunday
Readings drawn from the Institute for Scripture Research (ISR) Scriptures

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Welcome. Today's lecture examines one of the most widely misunderstood teachings in biblical history: the command to "turn the other cheek." For centuries, this has been misinterpreted as a blanket mandate for absolute pacifism. However, a precise operational and historical analysis of the text reveals something entirely different.

PART 1: The Context of Incarceration and Survival

To understand the Gospel of Matthew, you must understand the shadow of the prison system that looms over it. The text is deeply connected to the imprisonment of John the Baptist. While confined in a dungeon—likely the fortress of Machaerus—John experienced the brutal, isolated reality of ancient incarceration, ultimately leading to his execution as detailed in Matthew 14.

Jesus was not preaching in a vacuum. He was delivering instructions with the acute awareness that His followers and His own family were facing imprisonment. When Jesus speaks in Matthew 5:39, saying, *"But I tell you not to resist an evil person. But whoever slaps you on your right cheek, turn the other to him also,"* He is providing calculated survival instructions to "roll with the punches", for those living in incarceration or under the absolute, crushing weight of a penal system.

In any modern correctional institution, just as in ancient holding cells, survival requires strict obedience to a system of law, both official and unofficial. "Turning the other cheek" is a requirement for survival. If you are struck by an oppressive guard or an institutional gang member, retaliating with physical violence will only ensure your destruction. It is a cycle of anger and revenge that will get you killed—or, in modern terms, shanked by the gangs.

By turning the other cheek, an inmate refuses to escalate a fatal physical conflict while simultaneously maintaining their internal, spiritual integrity. It is a bold, creative, and nonviolent defiance that breaks the cycle of retaliation. Any advice Jesus gives about submitting to wicked, violent people must be read as the profound, life-saving advice of a man teaching His friends how to survive the brutality of a jail cell.

PART 2: The Mandate for Self-Defense in the Free World

Do not confuse institutional survival tactics with weakness. Outside the walls of a prison, Jesus was a firm, uncompromising teacher of self-defense.

When operating in the free world, preparation and the defense of one's life and family are paramount. In Luke 22:36, Jesus gives a direct, tactical command to His disciples: *"But now, he who has a money bag, let him take it, and likewise a knapsack; and he who has no sword, let him sell his garment and buy one."* He expected His followers to be armed and capable of defending themselves against the lethal threats of the road, without hiding or cloaking their defensive arms. You do not sell your protective outer clothing to buy a weapon unless you are fully expected to protect your life.

Jesus drew a hard, unyielding line between personal self-defense and military conquest for kingdom expansion. When standing before the Roman authorities, He stated with absolute clarity in John 18:36: *"My kingdom is not of this world. If My kingdom were of this world, My servants would fight, so that I should not be delivered to the Jews; but now My kingdom is not from here."*

He commanded Peter to put away his sword in the Garden of Gethsemane because Peter was attempting to use violence to defend the *spiritual kingdom* and alter a divine mission. Jesus would not use force to take land, conquer nations, or expand His religious influence.

Conclusion

The doctrine is clear, practical, and highly situational. When you are confined, outmatched by an occupying force, or living inside a prison system, you turn the other cheek. You break the cycle of violence, you maintain your dignity, and you survive. But as free citizens walking in the world, you arm yourselves, you remain vigilant, and you fiercely defend your life against evil.

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